

HEIRLOOM

A FILM BASED ON A TRUE STORY

OFFICIAL SELECTION

27th Kyoto International Student Film & Video Festival
京都国際学生映画祭
2025

OFFICIAL SELECTION
2024
NOLA
WOLF
FESTIVAL

OFFICIAL SELECTION
2024
BERLIN
SHORTS
AWARD

OFFICIAL SELECTION
2024
PHOENIX
SHORTS
AWARD

OFFICIAL SELECTION
2024
CHICAGO
FILMMAKER
AWARDS

OFFICIAL SELECTION
2024
SAN FRANCISCO
ARTHOUSE
SHORT
FESTIVAL

OFFICIAL SELECTION
2024
MADRID
ARTHOUSE
FILM FESTIVAL

RUI SONG

HEIRLOOM

“YOU DON'T KNOW HIM”

A FILM BY RUI SONG PRODUCED BY LE REN AND RUI SONG SCRIPT BY RUI SONG
CASTING EDRIC YOUNG AND DYVINE WALLACE AND MICHELE GATES AND SHINE AND NEO
CASTING BY RUI SONG COSTUMES BY LE REN EDITED BY RUI SONG
CO-PRODUCTION DESIGNER YIXIAN GUO AND YUANYUAN ZHENG ASSISTANT DIRECTOR SHUCHI LIANG
DIRECTOR OF PHOTOGRAPHY YIMING SI CAMERA ASSISTANT BO WANG
GAFFER JESSE COLLIER SUTTERLEY KEY GRIP XIAOFENG WU SOUND KELLY DUONG
MAKEUP ARTIST MENGGEN SHI SCREEN SUPERVISOR RUI YAN PRODUCTION ASSISTANT JINGBO WANG
COLOR GRADING BY ADAM BERK CTSF

Screened at: Museum of Kyoto Film Theater, Kyoto · The Roxie & Balboa Theatre, San Francisco · City Base Cinemas, San Antonio

Rui Song · Director / Writer
ruisong.studio@gmail.com

LOGLINE

Following his coming out, a young man is astonished to discover his parents not only knew but accepted his homosexuality — contingent upon the condition that he must father a child to inherit the cherished family heirloom. Overwhelmed, he engages in a heated dispute with his parents, yet the accidental shattering of the heirloom unveils a long-buried secret.



SHORT SYNOPSIS

The film unfolds entirely during a birthday dinner in San Francisco. Kevin, a Chinese-American, and his African-American chef boyfriend Liam live happily together with their cat. On Kevin's 25th birthday, his first-generation Chinese immigrant parents visit from New York to pass down a treasured family heirloom. Kevin decides to come out to them — only to discover they already knew, and accepted him. But there is a condition: he must have a child to inherit the heirloom. Amidst a heated argument, the cat accidentally shatters the heirloom, exposing it as a fake — a revelation that forces Kevin's father to confess a long-buried secret. The film closes with the question of the heir left unresolved — and with Kevin's parents extending a warm invitation for Liam to join them for the holidays.

Directed and written by Rui Song. Produced by Le Ren. Starring Edric Young Zeng and Dyvine Wallace.

LONG SYNOPSIS

Kevin, a Chinese-American, lives in San Francisco with his boyfriend Liam, an African-American chef. The couple shares their home with an adorable cat. Today marks Kevin's 25th birthday, and in anticipation of his parents' visit from New York (first-generation Chinese immigrants), Kevin and Liam meticulously prepare their home. As a chef, Liam cooks Chinese-themed cuisine for Kevin's parents. The day holds profound significance for Kevin: he not only plans to come out, but also intends to receive a crucial family heirloom.

Appetizers

Kevin's parents arrive punctually with a cake and gifts. As the only son in the family, Kevin is set to inherit a precious family heirloom; his parents present it to him immediately. The four of them share a meal, and during a lively icebreaking game initiated by Kevin's father, Kevin seizes the opportunity to confess his long-prepared truth: he is gay. Surprisingly, his parents were already aware — and accepted him. Overjoyed, Kevin loses himself in celebration, dancing with Liam in the living room. Then his mother's remark — "You need to have a child" — abruptly brings him back to reality.

Main Course

The seemingly irrational demand triggers strong resistance in Kevin and erupts into a fierce argument. Kevin defiantly suggests their cat as a symbolic child, pushing back against his mother's skepticism. But the dispute is suddenly silenced by a "dong" and a "meow" — the family heirloom has been shattered by the cat. As the four stand bewildered, Liam, unfamiliar with Chinese antiques, picks up a fragment. Inscribed in his mother tongue: Made in China. The English revelation exposes the truth — the heirloom is not an antique. Kevin's father, standing nearby, finally discloses a long-concealed secret.

Dessert

Seated around the table, savoring the dessert Liam prepared, Kevin's father appears to exhale a sigh of relief. The truth: even before Kevin's parents were married, the heirloom had broken due to his father's playful carelessness. Fearing reproach, his father had commissioned an identical replica in Chinatown. With the secret unveiled, Kevin tells his parents that without the original heirloom, there is no need for an heir. Avoiding a direct response, Kevin's parents instead invite Liam to join them for Thanksgiving and Christmas. The film closes on this note.

DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT



On the set of Heirloom, San Francisco, February 2024.

This film began with a wish I have held quietly for years. As a member of the LGBTQ+ community, I have never openly come out to my parents. They love me, and I have considered telling them. But I hesitate — to demand that they understand me through the lens of a society they did not grow up in feels selfish.

The story that finally pushed me to write *Heirloom* was not mine, but a friend's. He is gay, financially independent, living alone in the United States. To negotiate his freedom, he made an agreement with his parents back in China: he would father a child through surrogacy, and his parents would take the child to China to raise as grandparents. He could continue to live in the U.S. without marriage. The arrangement worked for him. But I could not stop thinking about the child — and the strange ways love bargains with itself across borders.

I chose to make *Heirloom* a comedy because I do not believe LGBTQ+ family stories must arrive solemn to arrive serious. The film unfolds entirely at a dinner table. A son comes out. The parents already knew. A cat breaks an heirloom. A father confesses the heirloom was a fake all along. Nobody resolves the question of whether there will be a child. Everyone keeps eating dessert. This is, in my experience, how family negotiations actually feel — absurd, anti-climactic, and somehow tender anyway.

I trained as a choreographer before I trained as a filmmaker, and *Heirloom* carries that training. I use music and rhythm to shape how the story moves; the protagonist drifts into his interior world through dance; jump cuts carry emotional weight that words cannot. I hope this lends the film a peculiar texture — something between a sitcom dinner scene and a quiet Sunday afternoon.

If *Heirloom* brings warmth, or recognition, or a bit of relief to LGBTQ+ families watching, that is the most I could ask.

— Rui Song, Director

SUBJECT BACKGROUND

In Chinese-American family life, the conversation around queerness is rarely a single declaration. It is a slow, ongoing negotiation — between immigrant parents shaped by a Confucian framework of lineage and continuity, and their American-raised children who have absorbed a different vocabulary of selfhood. Acceptance, when it comes, often arrives bundled with conditions. The most enduring of these is the question of an heir.

For LGBTQ+ children of the Chinese diaspora, surrogacy has emerged as one of the most quietly transformative responses to this tension. As reproductive technology has advanced and as same-sex marriage has gained legal recognition in many parts of the world, family-formation paths once unavailable to queer individuals are now real options — though they remain ethically and emotionally complex. For some queer Chinese diaspora families, a surrogate child has become a way of resolving — or postponing — the irreconcilable: how to be openly queer in one country, while remaining a continuing son in another.

Heirloom sits inside this conversation. The film does not argue for or against surrogacy. It watches what happens at the dinner table when the question arrives — and how a family keeps eating through it.



SCREENING HISTORY

Festival Selections

2025

27th Kyoto International Student Film & Video Festival

Museum of Kyoto Film Theater, Kyoto, Japan · February 6–9, 2025

2024

22nd Another Hole in the Head Film Festival (SF IndieFest)

Strictly Local II program · Balboa Theater & The Roxie Theater, San Francisco · December 8, 2024

San Antonio QFest LGBT International Film Festival

Student Filmmakers program · City Base Cinemas, San Antonio, TX · October 12, 2024

Theatrical Screening

The Roxie Theater, San Francisco

May 7, 2025

Additional Recognition

Best Editing — Chicago Filmmaker Awards (2024). Best LGBTQ Short — San Francisco Arthouse Short Festival, Berlin Shorts Award, Phoenix Shorts, Madrid Arthouse Film Festival (2024).

TECHNICAL SPECIFICATIONS

Runtime	13 minutes (13:17)
Country of Production	United States
Year of Completion	2024
Language	English
Subtitles	English
Aspect Ratio	2.35:1
Frame Rate	23.976 fps
Resolution	3840 × 2160 (4K UHD)
Color	Color
Camera	RED Komodo 6K
Sound	Stereo
Color Grading	DaVinci Resolve
Production Banner	California College of the Arts (CCA) MFA Thesis Film
Shooting Location	San Francisco, California
Shooting Period	February 2024
Genre	Comedy / Drama / LGBTQ+



FEATURED CAST

Edric Young Zeng as Kevin

A passionate actor based in San Francisco, Edric brings experience in theater, modeling, and film. Beyond his own performance work, he mentors aspiring actors — a commitment rooted in his belief that nurturing talent is essential to the future of the industry.

Dyvine Wallace as Liam

Dyvine Wallace plays Liam with quiet warmth — an African-American chef whose patience holds the dinner together while the family around him unravels. Based in Arizona, Dyvine's training spans acting, runway, and brand modeling.



Michele Gates as Kevin's Mom

Michele Gates plays Kevin's mother — the matriarch whose demand for an heir ignites the film's central conflict. Based between San Francisco and Los Angeles, her performance finds the love beneath the imposition.

Shine Wu as Kevin's Dad

Based in San Francisco, Shine brings passion and determination to the role of Kevin's father — a first-generation Chinese immigrant patriarch whose love expresses itself through expectation. His commitment to the craft of performance shapes one of the film's anchoring presences.

FILMMAKER BIOS



Rui Song

Director · Writer · Editor

Rui Song is a filmmaker working at the intersection of cinema, dance, and emerging technology. She received her MFA in Film from California College of the Arts (CCA) in 2024, where she directed *Heirloom* (2024), a comedic short on LGBTQ+ family dynamics that has screened at the Kyoto International Student Film & Video Festival, San Francisco's Another Hole in the Head Film Festival, and San Antonio QFest LGBT International Film Festival.

Trained originally as a choreographer, Rui's filmmaking integrates dance and rhythmic editing as core narrative tools rather than embellishments. She is currently pursuing an MS in Computer Science at Northeastern University (2025–2027), where her research focuses on how AI can expand — rather than replace — the craft of filmmaking. Her work explores queer family relationships, cultural inheritance, and the role of technology in reshaping how stories get told.

Le Ren — Producer, Costume Designer

Le is a film producer with a background in business. She brings a wealth of experience in budgeting and program management, paired with a passion for storytelling and a commitment to producing impactful cinematic work.

Yiming Si — Director of Photography

Founder of Pisci Production. Yiming Si focuses on visual expression across both film photography and filmmaking. His DP credits include *Low Battery* (2022), *Since Then* (2022), *Adagio* (2023), *Let Me Out* (2023), *Meant to Be Your Wife* (2023), *Kill Me Please* (2023), *Magic Mushroom* (2024), and *Heirloom* (2024).

Jesse Collier Sutterley — Gaffer

Jesse Collier Sutterley is a documentary film director and editor from the San Francisco Bay Area. Sutterley was the editor of the award-winning feature *Ultimate Sacrifices: Cpt. Jennifer Moreno* and the award-winning film *From Mexico To Vietnam*, alongside short films including *Buck Southworth* and *The Bataan Death March*. As a historian, Sutterley deeply enjoys retelling the stories of the past and collecting shared histories for future generations. His work focuses primarily on grief and the human experience of loss.

Bo Wang — Camera Assistant

A filmmaker drawn to realistic cinematography. Born in Nanjing, China, Bo received her film education in both China and the United States, where she has been consistently studying and developing her craft as a cinematographer.

Xiaofeng Wu — Key Grip

A senior film major at California College of the Arts (CCA), Xiaofeng has been working in the film industry for six years, specializing in cinematography and lighting. He has contributed to numerous student projects and commercial advertisements — including the 2018 Chinese New Year campaign for KFC in Fuzhou — and has worked on over twenty student thesis short films. His projects have been recognized at international festivals such as the 77th Salerno Film Festival.

Eva Guo — Art Director

Eva is a graduate student in Film at CCA, deepening her understanding of human emotion through visual storytelling. Her work as an art director includes the short films Thief (2020), Her (2020), Wagner (2021), Mirror (2021), and Heirloom (2024).

Kelly Duong — Sound Recordist

Kelly is based in and grew up in San Francisco. Her mission is to create representation and amplify voices around queer and racial issues. She is currently pursuing a bachelor's degree in BECA and Cinema at San Francisco State University. Working primarily in sound — both production and post-production — Kelly's recent credits include Hammer of Witches, a film that won three awards and was screened at multiple festivals.

Q&A WITH THE FILMMAKER

1. Why did you begin filmmaking?

As a director, my journey into filmmaking began with my background in dance. Dance became a vehicle for personal expression and growth, and earned me recognition on the competitive dance stage. I started as a dance teacher, and over time gained opportunities to choreograph for celebrities, stage productions, and live events. These experiences opened the door to the world behind the screen, sparking a deep interest in filmmaking. After graduation, I chose to pursue my MFA at CCA, immersing myself in the craft of film production. I want to leverage the skills cultivated through dance — rhythm, embodiment, spatial sense — to make my mark in narrative film, music videos, and commercial work, presenting audiences with visually distinct stories.

2. How were you changed by the process of making Heirloom?

Making Heirloom taught me to trust comedy. My early drafts treated surrogacy as a serious issue to be examined, and the script kept getting heavier. The breakthrough came when I gave up trying to resolve anything — when I let the cat break the heirloom, let the father confess his old lie, and trusted the audience to feel what mattered without me explaining it. I learned that warmth can be a form of seriousness too.

3. What values are imbued in this film, and where do those values come from?

The values woven into Heirloom come from personal experience, observation, and reflection. Love and acceptance are at the forefront — inspired by my own journey as a member of the LGBTQ+ community navigating identity and family. The portrayal of family dynamics reflects my belief that familial bonds extend beyond blood, formed through shared experience and unconditional love. The film's approach to surrogacy is deliberately layered, acknowledging the ethical complexity and emotional weight involved. Overall, the values Heirloom carries are rooted in authenticity, empathy, and inclusivity — aiming to provoke conversation while celebrating the diversity of human experience.

4. What challenges did you face during the making of Heirloom?

One of the biggest challenges was portraying the parents' awareness of their son's homosexuality in a way that felt authentic and respectful. We went through numerous iterations of the script, constantly mindful of avoiding stereotypes and misrepresentation of LGBTQ+ experiences. As an LGBTQ+ filmmaker myself — though not a gay man — I was particularly conscious of this responsibility. To address it, we sought feedback from a range of sources: LGBTQ+ professors, our actors, crew members, and our school's LGBTQ+ community. By considering diverse perspectives, we developed a version of the script that felt genuine and inclusive. We also folded in self-deprecating humor to acknowledge and gently challenge stereotypes, adding nuance to the characters and their interactions.

5. What do you hope audiences will take away from the film?

I hope audiences are touched by the warmth of the story and gain a fresh perspective on how LGBTQ+ families navigate relationships and conflict. Through *Heirloom*, I want to offer a glimpse into the complexity of LGBTQ+ family dynamics — and show that love and acceptance know no bounds. I also hope the film provides some spiritual support for the LGBTQ+ community, and encourages parents to better understand, support, and embrace their LGBTQ+ children.

6. The ending is open-ended — the family never resolves the question of surrogacy. Why?

Surrogacy is too complex a question to be resolved at a dinner table — and I was not interested in pretending otherwise. The single-location structure gave me a small frame for a big question, and the open ending was the only honest way to close it. I wanted to leave the audience the way the family is left: still chewing, still thinking, still holding the broken pieces.

The question of whether Kevin will have a child is not the question *Heirloom* is asking. The film is asking what we do when love arrives bundled with conditions we cannot accept. That question stays open.

PRESS

"In Heirloom, the filmmaker delves into the complexities of family, identity, and the evolving dynamics of LGBTQ+ relationships."

— Patrick Roy, *UniversalCinema Magazine*

"Heirloom: Navigating Family, Identity, and Surrogacy in LGBTQ+ Narratives"

Interview by Patrick Roy · *UniversalCinema Magazine* · September 2024

universalcinema.net/heirloom-navigating-family-identity-and-surrogacy-in-lgbtq-narratives

FULL CAST & CREW

CAST (in order of appearance)

Kevin	EDRIC YOUNG ZENG
Liam	DYVINE WALLACE
Kevin's Mom	MICHELE GATES
Kevin's Dad	SHINE WU
Cat	NEO

CREW

Director & Co-Producer	RUI SONG
Co-Producer	LE REN
Writer	RUI SONG
Assistant Director	SHUCI LIANG
Director of Photography	YIMING SI
Camera Assistant	BO WANG
Co-Production Designer	YUANYUAN ZHENG
Co-Production Designer	YIXIAN GUO
Gaffer	JESSE COLLIER SUTTERLEY
Key Grip	XIAOFENG WU
Sound	KELLY DUONG
Screen Supervisor	RUI YAN
Costume Designer	LE REN
Makeup Artist	MENGREN SHI
Production Assistant	JINGBO WANG

POST-PRODUCTION

Editor	RUI SONG
Sound Remixer	RUI SONG
Colorist	ADAM BERK, CTSF



HEIRLOOM

A film by Rui Song

Rui Song · Director / Writer
ruisong.studio@gmail.com

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